

policy: Southerners who owned more than \$20,000 in personal property would not be pardoned except by special application to the president.

As it turned out, Johnson's actions showed no vindictive desire to punish rich planters. He appointed governors from their class who in turn readmitted many members of the Southern elite, including former Confederates, to state offices. On the issue of land confiscation, Johnson ordered militarily seized lands to be returned to their previous owners. He also pardoned large numbers of individuals excluded under his Reconstruction plan.

Johnson's racism would not allow him to elevate Black people to social and political equality. He imagined that those who had been enslaved would remain under the influence of their former enslavers, voting as directed and giving more power to Southern leaders. He argued that suffrage was a matter of states' rights, not to be interfered with by the Federal government.

 7,000 The number of pardons granting amnesty to wealthy Southern landowners signed by President Johnson by 1866.

Johnson's obstructionism

The desire to enact Black suffrage was the most crucial goal that bound Radical Republicans together. The two leading figures in the movement were the Massachusetts Senator Charles Sumner and Pennsylvania Congressman Thaddeus Stevens. After the 1866 elections, the Radical Republican majority was so unassailable that Congress could override the President's veto. He even tried to veto the landmark 1866 Civil Rights Bill that granted citizenship and all its civil rights to Black Americans, rights that were subsequently enshrined in the Fourteenth Amendment. Johnson also opposed expanding Federal assistance to Black citizens in the South.

In March 1865, Congress created an organization known as the Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands—the “Freedmen's Bureau.” Employing fewer than 900 agents, the Bureau dispensed food, medicine, and supplies to former slaves. It also helped to establish schools for them and to mediate labor disputes. President Johnson opposed continued funding for the